



CONTROVERSIAL: Metropolitan Gurgan's (centre) consecration

Syrian Church or the Jacobites—owing allegiance to the Holy Patriarch of Antioch (POA) in Syria. These two have been continuously feuding in the courts over issues of interpretation of theology, canon laws, supremacy of their respective heads and most commonly, the ownership of assets, for over a century. But this latest rift has triggered a schism within osc.

The few Syrian churches in the US and Europe under POA have also been witnessing various rifts. The newly consecrated Metropolitan Gurgan belonged to a dissident group in Germany which, too, has recently disassociated from POA. Milithios said that a church in Germany, which was under POA, had faced revolts and the dissidents were led by Metropolitan Gurgan. "All these dissidents requested our help to break free from the clutches of POA and we helped them, which osc leadership should welcome," justifies Gurgan. His critics say the bishops went ahead with the consecration to eventually undermine the authority of osc and even form their own church. An osc leader adds they are being tempted by the riches and the assets the German monks have to offer.

Milithios's faction believes that osc leadership's antagonism to them has political overtones. "The osc leadership always remained pro-UDF and we were neutral in politics. They don't like it and want us out of osc and this is only a ruse," says a spokesperson. Milithios and his associates have often questioned the leadership's overt closeness to UDF leaders, such as Oommen Chandy. At the same time, the leadership accuses their rivals of being unnecessarily pro-Left, which is in contradiction with their political sympathies. "They are called Red Bishops who never miss an opportunity to ridicule UDF leaders or dub Congress's economic reforms as imperialist or bourgeois."

by M.G. Radhakrishnan

Clash of Cardinals

The long-standing rivalry among the different sections of the church in Kerala now assumes a political dimension

This controversy seems to have all the complicated trappings of an international espionage thriller. It began in November at Thrissur with the confidential consecration of Saverios Moosa Gurgan, a German monk, as a Metropolitan by two bishops of the Kerala-based Orthodox Syrian Church (osc), one of the wealthiest and most politically powerful non-Catholic churches in India. osc says the sanctification was done in the absence of both the supreme head, catholicos, Mar Baselios Didimos and his deputy, who are based in the headquarters in Kottayam. Metropolitan Gurgan has since headed the European Free Orthodox Church.

The two bishops of osc performed the consecration without any regrets. Yuhanon Mar Milithios, of osc's Thrissur diocese, one of the two bishops involved, says it won't hurt to have the support of a few foreign priests and followers, given the current imposition. He goes on to justify that osc synod had agreed to the consecration in August and a five-member committee had been formed to see it through, out of which three

members had given their consent. But osc leadership is in denial mode, saying the sanction was only to consider it. A spokesperson adds that even the catholicos-designate, who was in the committee and also the synod secretary, had opposed it later.

The issue has assumed an additional political dimension, as it has exposed the emerging rift between osc's leadership, which is pro-United Democratic Front (UDF) and Milithios's faction supporting the ruling Left Democratic Front (LDF).

Kerala-based osc has nine lakh members and claims its founder is St Thomas, one of the 12 apostles of Jesus Christ. It is one among a few minority churches scattered worldwide, which is rooted in Syria or Turkey, unlike the dominant European churches. In India, osc has two factions—a dominant one headed by the catholicos and the other, Orthodox

Bishops who did the consecration are being charged with undermining OSC's authority so as to establish their own order